✝ Christian Humanism — Cheat Sheet

Procadamia | Key Concepts, Definitions & Moral Framework

CH. 1 — FOUNDATIONS OF ETHICS

Term	Definition
Ethics	Branch of philosophy studying the moral goodness/badness of human actions
End / Intention	The purpose or goal toward which an action is directed (the "why")
Means	The actions or methods used to achieve an end (the "how")
First Principle	"Do good and avoid evil" — foundational moral truth, known through synderesis
Synderesis	The innate moral sense; the natural disposition to know the first principle

⚠️ The end does NOT justify the means — both must be morally good

CH. 2 — HAPPINESS (BEATITUDE)

Term	Definition
Beatitude	Perfect happiness; ultimate end of human existence (union with God)
Eudaimonia	Aristotle's term for flourishing / human happiness through virtue
Imperfect Happiness	Natural happiness achievable in this life (health, virtue, friendship)
Perfect Happiness	Supernatural happiness; vision of God (beatific vision); only in eternal life
Bonum	The Good — that which all things seek by their nature

Aquinas: Humans are oriented toward God as their ultimate end (telos); earthly goods are good but insufficient for perfect happiness

CH. 3 — THE FOUR TYPES OF LAW

Type	Definition
Eternal Law	God's rational governance of all creation; the source of all other law
Natural Law	Human reason's participation in eternal law; universally knowable moral truths
Divine (Positive) Law	Revealed law (Scripture, Ten Commandments, New Testament); guides to eternal life
Human Positive Law	Laws created by human authority; just only if in accord with natural law

Hierarchy: Eternal → Natural → Divine → Human. An unjust human law is no law at all (Aquinas)

"An unjust law is no law at all." — Augustine / Aquinas

CH. 4 — CONSCIENCE

Term	Definition
Conscience	The practical judgment of reason about the morality of a concrete act
Certain Conscience	Firm, well-reasoned moral judgment — must always be followed
Doubtful Conscience	Uncertainty about morality — one must resolve doubt before acting
Erroneous Conscience	Mistaken moral judgment; vincible (culpable) vs. invincible (not culpable)
Vincible Ignorance	Could have known better; morally culpable
Invincible Ignorance	Couldn't have known better; not morally culpable
Formation	Duty to educate/form one's conscience using reason, Scripture, and Church teaching

One must always follow a certain conscience, even if objectively wrong — but has a duty to form conscience correctly

CH. 5 — HUMAN ACTS

Term	Definition
Human Act	Act performed knowingly and freely — subject to moral evaluation
Act of Man	Act done without knowledge or free will (reflex, sleep, instinct) — not morally evaluated
Knowledge	Must know what one is doing for it to be a human act
Freedom	Must act voluntarily (without compulsion) for moral responsibility
Voluntariness	Degree to which an act is freely chosen

Impediments to Human Acts	
Ignorance	Lack of knowledge; reduces/removes responsibility
Passion	Strong emotion; antecedent passion reduces freedom; consequent does not
Fear	Can diminish freedom; grave fear can reduce culpability
Violence / Force	External compulsion; removes voluntariness entirely

CH. 6 — MORALITY OF HUMAN ACTS

The Three Fonts of Morality	Description
Object	The act itself — what is done (intrinsic moral quality)
Intention / End	Why the act is done — the agent's purpose
Circumstances	Who, what, when, where, how, and effects — can increase or decrease morality

Key Principles	
Intrinsic Evil	Acts evil by their object regardless of intention (murder, lying under oath)
Double Effect	A single act with 2 effects (good + bad) may be permitted if: act is good/neutral; bad effect not the means; bad not intended; proportionate reason
Cooperation	Formal = shares evil intention (always wrong); Material = provides assistance (may be permitted)

⚠️ For an act to be morally good: ALL THREE fonts must be good. One defect makes the act morally deficient.

CORE PRINCIPLES AT A GLANCE

- **First Principle:** "Do good and avoid evil"
- **End ≠ justifies means:** both end AND means must be good
- **Four types of law:** Eternal → Natural → Divine → Human
- **Unjust law:** has no binding moral force (Augustine/Aquinas)
- **Conscience:** always follow certain conscience; duty to form it correctly
- **Human act** = knowledge + freedom (both required for moral evaluation)
- **Three fonts:** Object + Intention + Circumstances — ALL must be good
- **Intrinsic evils** are always wrong regardless of intention
- **Double effect:** 4 conditions must ALL be met
- **Beatitude** = ultimate end; only God fully satisfies human longing

Key thinkers: **Aristotle** (eudaimonia, virtue ethics) | **Thomas Aquinas** (natural law, four types of law, three fonts) | **Augustine** (unjust law, beatitude)